

ASUS Eee PC 1005HA

If I'm not mistaken, ASUS must have launched more than 20 models of its popular Eee PC netbook in the past year-and-a-half. With that kind of track record, it's no surprise that this latest entry is one of the most well-rounded netbooks on the market. The ASUS Eee PC 1005HA has a chassis similar to the elegant Eee PC 1008HA and the same Intel Atom processor, 1 GB of RAM, and 160 GB hard drive as the 1008HA. And its high-capacity battery lasts just short of four hours on JoliCloud, making this one of the longest-running netbooks yet.

Inspired design

A member of ASUS' Seashell family, the 1005HA is the 1008HA's chunkier twin. Though less svelte than the inch-thick 1008HA, the 1005HA draws from the same gene pool—a fact demonstrated by its curved panels and sharp look. Gone, however, is the uniform body of the 1008HA; no plastic covers the edges or hides the ports. Its glossy lid is covered in a scratch-resistant in-fusion finish, which is far from fingerprint-resistant, so you'll need to keep a cloth handy.

The vital stats measure 10.2 x 6.9 x 1.4 inches (25.9 x 17.5 x 3.5 cm). It also weighs noticeably more than the 1008HA, but the 1.4 kg 1005HA netbook didn't strain my shoulders even with the charger.

Ports

On the left side are a USB and full VGA port. On the right side are a 3-in-1 card reader, an Ethernet port, two USB ports (bringing the USB total to three, one more than the 1008HA), and headphone and microphone jacks.



The keyboard and touchpad

The Eee PC 1005HA includes the same comfortable, spacious keyboard found on the 1008HA. However, there are no spaces between the raised black matte keys, which I found flat (I prefer them raised), but they did provide nice, tactile feedback. Moreover, the right *Shift* key is full sized and directly below the *Enter* key. A touchpad on/off button sits at the top left of the keyboard.

The 2.5 x 1.5-inch (6.3 x 3.8 cm) touchpad blends

in with the system's deck and is covered with small braille-like dots. Unlike most netbooks, the pad had very little friction, and navigating the desktop didn't require much backtracking. As with other Eee PCs, the touchpad also supports multi-touch gestures; using two fingers to pinch the pad and zoom in on a Web page was easy, and the image quickly rendered in its new size. The single mouse button was comfortable for making selections.

Display, audio, and the webcam

The 10.1-inch (25.6 cm), 1024 x 600-pixel resolution LED-backlit display on the 1005HA allows Web pages and windows to fit-to-size on the screen. While the videos looked smooth, and the colours were bright, tilting the glossy screen back 45 degrees resulted in a slight glare; horizontal viewing angles were better. From afar, the inch-thick, glossy black bezel looked as if the screen was flush with the frame. Up close, however, you could clearly make out the raised frame.

Above the display, a 1.3 megapixel webcam provided clear images. The speakers, located at the bottom front edge of the system, allowed us to hear the soundtrack loud and clear.

The processor

Configured with the same 1.66-GHz Intel Atom N280 processor and 1GB of RAM as the ASUS Eee PC 1008HA, I didn't see much change in everyday performance on the 1005HA.

The Intel GMA 950 integrated graphics chip with 128 MB of shared memory was able to playback a downloaded high-definition 720p video clip smoothly with no hiccups.

Verdict

An attractive design, comfortable keyboard with appropriately placed keys, and almost four-and-a-half hours of runtime (on Ubuntu Netbook Remix) makes the ASUS' Eee PC 1005HA the most well rounded Eee PC to date. And it's also one of the most affordable netbooks with its feature set. Those craving for a thinner netbook will be happier with the Eee PC 1008HA, but will have to pay a little more and be prepared for a slightly less battery life.

